

BHASKAR PAUL



CRAVING ATTENTION: India saw 71 m domestic and 25 m international passengers last year

Farmers of Nashik can now fly to Mumbai and back the same day after completing their business and the mining entrepreneurs of Bellary, too, are discovering the ease with which they can access their markets and consumers. Earlier, travel between Delhi and Chennai took over 40 hours by rail and cost Rs 12,000 by air, but now passengers have the choice of travelling by air at much lower fares. Says Sanjay Reddy, managing director of GVK Group, which is privatising Mumbai's international airport, "India has not seen the real boom yet. The key to growth will be non-metro airports."

The impact of the aviation revolution is not just restricted to small businesses. With low-cost carriers flying into Goa, the tourism industry in the state has changed completely. Today there's no such thing as "off-season" with leisure travellers coming by plane-loads throughout the year as it's cheaper during off-season. Singh says, "Almost all airlines have started flights or have increased their services between Goa and other cities after we started operating on this sector. It has had a huge impact

on the tourism industry." Apart from democratising air travel, the boom has also busted myths about small towns and cities as the heaviest traffic comes from here.

From 10 million domestic passengers annually till 2002 to 71 million in 2007, the journey of Indian aviation has been rapid but it has also started telling on the infrastructure as airports are bursting at the seams. Mumbai, for instance, handled 26 million passengers this year while Delhi handled 24 million and the figure is expected to touch 108 million in Delhi by 2016. The CAPA report states that in order to sustain the expected traffic growth and at the same time ensure safe operations, significant investment will be required to upgrade and modernise the airports. The government has planned a \$9 billion (Rs 36,000 crore) investment by 2010, which involves private sector participation. Experts feel it's important to invest in critical areas like human resources in modernisation of air traffic management systems, air safety and airport security. Problems apart, be it low-cost or full service carriers, there's a little bit of sky on offer for every Indian because ambition has taken wing. ■

BRIJESH KUMAR, chairman, Indian Airlines, 1994

"Indian Airlines is the only one forced to operate in loss-making sectors because it's a national need."